SUMMARY

The historical society archive accumulated significant data debt over nearly 10 years, across rotating rounds of volunteers handling its taxonomy. “Category” was an uncontrolled term, applied inconsistently to both object type and subject. As a result, the “Category” field had ballooned to over 300 terms, hindering searchability and interoperability. I used OpenRefine and Python to audit the existing records and develop a proposed object type taxonomy. Working with the archive team, I helped establish a final list of 54 categories, separate subject terms from object types, and update the FileMaker database to enable consistent cataloging going forward.

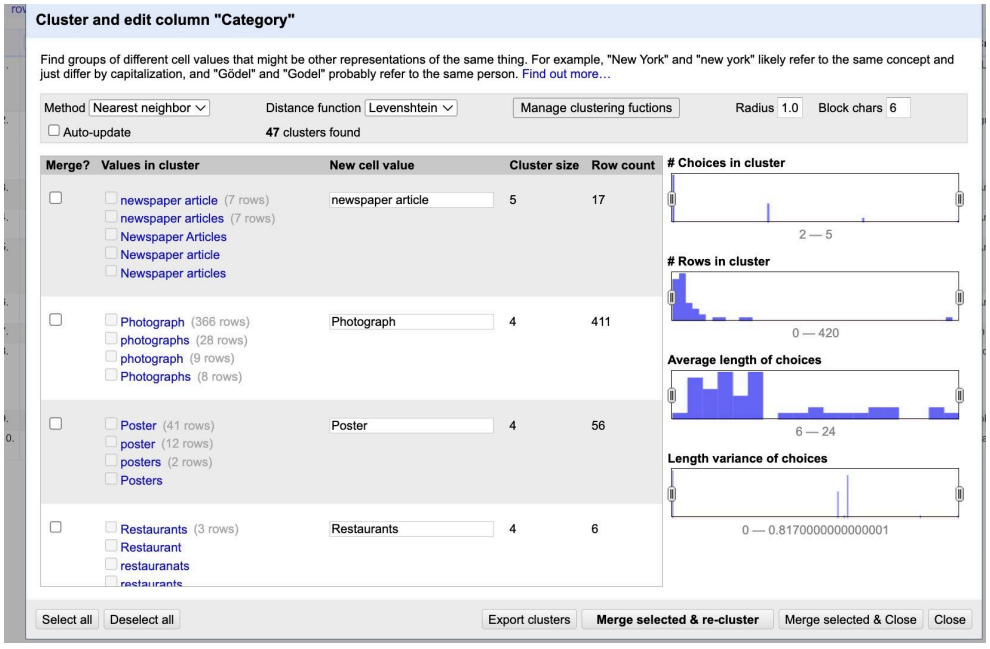
PROBLEM

The archive team is making a concerted effort to digitize its materials, but inconsistent past cataloging practices have made this difficult for the volunteer team. With object type and subject combined in a single field, records were difficult to categorize consistently and search by the different ways users were actually looking for them. We needed a better taxonomy to proceed efficiently and sustainably.

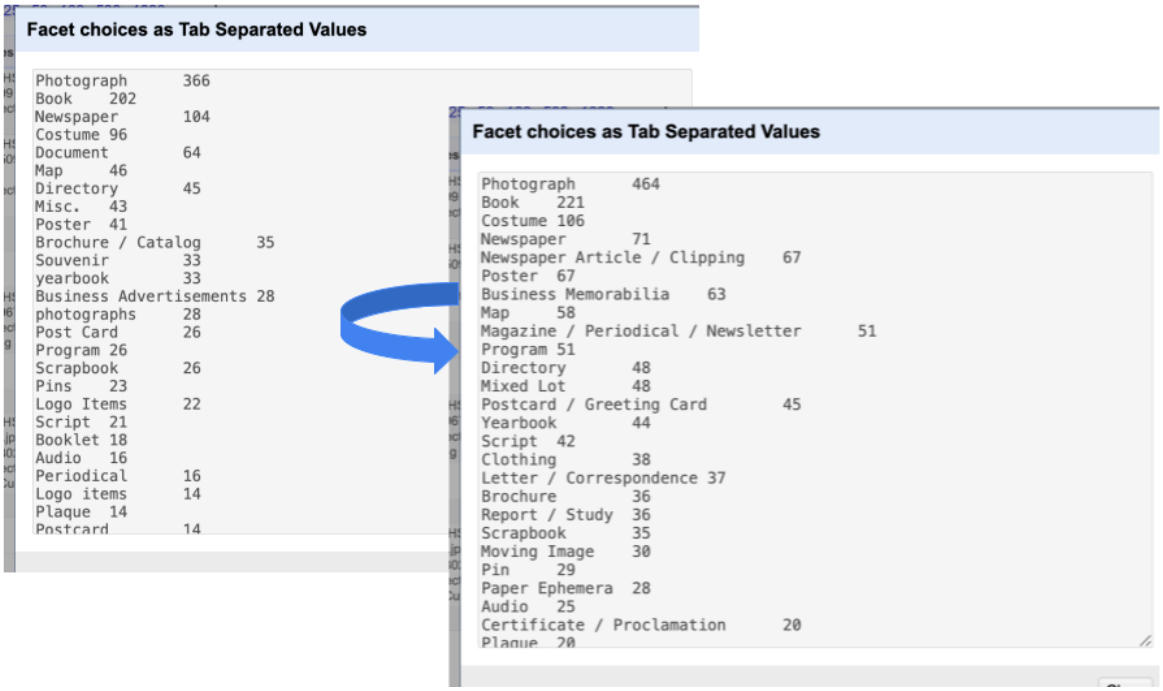
PROCESS

Step 1 - Data Cleaning

Using OpenRefine, I identified duplicate categories and consolidated them through clustering:



Next, I manually reviewed objects in categories with fewer than 5 objects. Objects that fit in existing categories were reassigned. If type was unclear, objects were placed in holding categories for further review



Step 2 - Taxonomy Design

Based on the initial audit, I proposed a draft taxonomy. I reviewed it with fellow interns and the historical society's archivist, and we aligned on a final list of 54 categories. We wrote definitions and created examples so that each object type would make sense to future catalogers.

Category	Definition
Architect's Rendering / Blueprint	Architect's redering of a building or structure; construction blueprint
Architectural Salvage	Objects or materials collected from a building site, demolition, or structure.
Art Print	Duplicate of an original creative work, generally meant for display or decoration. Not for advertising or promoting purposes (see: Poster)
Audio	Sound, voice, or music recorded for playback. The description must note the type of recording or file, such as "cassette", "vinyl record", or "mp3."
Badge	Uniform component signifying position or rank, usually meant to be affixed to clothing.
Book	Formally published and bound fictional or non-fictional works.
Brochure	Informational pamphlet developed by a business, organization, etc.
Business / Office Equipment	Items for use in an office or business
Catalog	Publication listing items for sale or auction
Certificate / Proclamation	Commemorative paper issued by an school, organization, or government recognizing a milestone, achievement, or change declaration

A major challenge was deciding what to do with blended subject/object type categories that had been acting as placeholders, notably several types of "Memorabilia," including "School

Memorabilia," "MGM Memorabilia," and "City Memorabilia." These categories fulfilled the need to tag by both object type and subject, but we recognized that this approach was unsustainable.

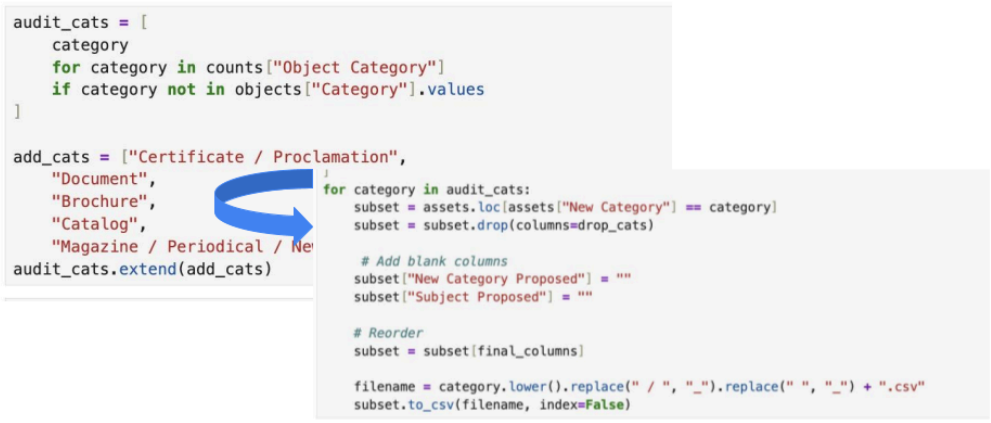
We agreed that subject terms were needed separately from object type. I drafted an initial list of 33 subject terms based on a frequency count of terms in the archive. To avoid losing information during the transition, I assigned subject tags based on the original categories. For example, "Business Memorabilia" records received relevant subjects such as "Culver City Businesses" and "Culver City Restaurants."

Category	New Category Proposed	Subject Proposed
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Restaurants
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Restaurants
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		Culver City Businesses
Business Memorabilia		MGM Studios

We will continue to implement and test this subject taxonomy as we digitize new materials.

Step 3 - Manual Audits

I used Python to identify records in categories we were deprecating. These objects needed to be reviewed and reassigned.



I created CSVs of these records for manual review and wrote an instructions document for volunteers to follow during the audit. We then reviewed the records against the new object type taxonomy and reassigned them to the appropriate categories.



RecordSeria	Asset Title	Category	New Category Proposed	Proposed Subject
1084	Culver City Historic Preservation Advisory C	Document	Report / Study	Culver City Municipal History
1089	Culver City 75th Commemorative Magazine	Document	Magazine / Periodical / Newsletter	Culver City Municipal History
1090	Culver City High School 50th Reunion "mer	Document	Ledger / Record	Culver City Schools
1091	Culver City High School 50th reunion invita	Document	Letter / Correspondence	Culver City Schools

Once the manual audit was completed, I updated the FileMaker database, creating validated fields for Object Type and Subject. I imported the new values for existing object records to establish a foundation for search.

RESULTS

- Reduced object type taxonomy from 384 to 54 agreed-upon terms
- Separated object type and subject into distinct fields
- Created an Object Type and Subject taxonomy definitions document for catalogers
- Added validated fields to Filemaker to support future cataloging consistency
- Established an initial subject taxonomy of 33 terms for further testing and refinement